

ZI HAUR PANG

Email: zihaurpang@gmail.com Website: <https://zihaurpang.github.io/>

EDUCATION

Kyoto University

Doctorate of Philosophy in Intelligent Science and Technology

Advisor: [Tatsuya Kawahara](#)

Kyoto, Japan

Apr 2024 - Present

Kyoto University

Master of Informatics in Intelligent Science and Technology

Advisor: [Tatsuya Kawahara](#)

Kyoto, Japan

Apr 2022 - Mar 2024

UCSI University

Bachelor of Science (Hons) Actuarial Science

Advisor: [Yue Fang Loh](#)

Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia

Jan 2017 - Dec 2020

EXPERIENCE

Agency for Science, Technology and Research (A*STAR)

Research Scholar

Singapore, Singapore

Dec 2025 - Present

- Designed and implemented a psychology-grounded MLLM evaluation benchmark and proposed a new emotion-centric architecture incorporating reinforcement learning.

Skyris AI

Intern, Machine Learning Engineer

Shenzhen, China

Aug 2025 - Oct 2025

- Developed an affective spoken dialogue framework for a companion pet robot and a multimodal speech-to-motion generation model for emotion-aligned behaviors.

Boise State University

Research Scholar

Idaho, United States

Jun 2025 - Jul 2025

- Designed and implemented a research project evaluating the impact of emotion-aware conversational robots in human-robot interaction.

Kyoto University

Teaching Assistant

Kyoto, Japan

Apr 2024 - Aug 2024

- Assisted in teaching the *Perspective in Informatics 2* course by preparing instructional materials, and reviewing student assessments.

AirAsia.Com Travel Sdn. Bhd.

Data Scientist

Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia

Sept 2020 - Mar 2022

- Designed machine learning and statistical models for user personalization across multiple business lines.

UCSI University

Research Assistant

Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia

May 2020 - Dec 2020

- Designed a research project to model and predict the COVID-19 situation in Malaysia using Deep Learning models.

SIC Co. Ltd.

Intern, Data Analyst

Fukuoka, Japan

Oct 2019 - Dec 2019

- Conducted market research on the Malaysian beauty salon industry, developed a data visualization dashboard, and designed a data management system for improved efficiency.

PUBLICATIONS

[1] Paralinguistic Emotion-Aware Validation Timing Detection in Japanese Empathetic Spoken Dialogue
Zi Haur Pang, Yahui Fu, Yuan Gao, Tatsuya Kawahara.

In *Proceedings of IEEE International Conference on Acoustics, Speech, and Signal Processing (ICASSP)*, 2026.

[2] Still Thinking or Stopped Talking? Dialogue Silence Intention Classification Using Multimodal Large Language Model

Muyun Wu, **Zi Haur Pang**, Koji Inoue, Tatsuya Kawahara.

In *Proceedings of IEEE International Conference on Acoustics, Speech, and Signal Processing (ICASSP)*, 2026.

- [3] Multilingual and Continuous Backchannel Prediction: A Cross-lingual Study
Koji Inoue, Mikey Elmers, Yahui Fu, **Zi Haur Pang**, Taiga Mori, Divesh Lala, Keiko Ochi, Tatsuya Kawahara.
In *Proceedings of International Workshop Spoken Dialogue Systems (IWSDS)*, 2026.
- [4] Does the Appearance of Autonomous Conversational Robots Affect User Spoken Behaviors in Real-World Conference Interactions?
Zi Haur Pang, Yahui Fu, Divesh Lala, Mikey Elmers, Koji Inoue, Tatsuya Kawahara.
In *Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA '25)*, 2025.
- [5] Human-Like Embodied AI Interviewer: Employing Android ERICA in Real International Conference
Zi Haur Pang, Yahui Fu, Divesh Lala, Mikey Elmers, Koji Inoue, Tatsuya Kawahara.
In *Proceedings of the 31st International Conference on Computational Linguistics (COLING)*, 2025.
- [6] Minority-Aware Satisfaction Estimation in Dialogue Systems via Preference-Adaptive Reinforcement Learning
Yahui Fu, **Zi Haur Pang**, Tatsuya Kawahara.
In *Proceedings of the International Joint Conference on Natural Language Processing & Asia-Pacific Chapter of the Association for Computational Linguistics (IJCNLP-AACL)*, 2025.
- [7] Prompt-Guided Turn-Taking Prediction
Koji Inoue, Mikey Elmers, Yahui Fu, **Zi Haur Pang**, Divesh Lala, Keiko Ochi, Tatsuya Kawahara.
In *SIGdial Meeting on Discourse and Dialogue (SIGDIAL)*, 2025.
- [8] ScriptBoard: Designing modern spoken dialogue systems through visual programming
Divesh Lala, Mikey Elmers, Koji Inoue, **Zi Haur Pang**, Keiko Ochi, Tatsuya Kawahara.
In *Proceedings of International Workshop Spoken Dialogue Systems (IWSDS)*, 2025.
- [9] Acknowledgment of Emotional States: Generating Validating Responses for Empathetic Dialogue
Zi Haur Pang, Yahui Fu, Divesh Lala, Keiko Ochi, Koji Inoue, Tatsuya Kawahara.
In *Proceedings of International Workshop Spoken Dialogue Systems (IWSDS)*, 2024. **[Best Paper Nominee]**
- [10] Toward More Human-like SDSs: Advancing Emotional and Social Engagement in Embodied Conversational Agents
Zi Haur Pang.
In *Young Researchers' Roundtable on Spoken Dialogue Systems (YRRSDS)*, 2024.
- [11] Development and evaluation of a semi-autonomous parallel attentive listening system
Divesh Lala, Koji Inoue, Haruki Kawai, **Zi Haur Pang**, Mikey Elmers, Tatsuya Kawahara.
In *Asia-Pacific Signal and Information Processing Association Annual Summit and Conference (APSIPA)*, 2024.

AWARDS AND HONORS

Outstanding Research Award	2025
Awarded by <i>Kyoto University ICT Collaboration Promotion Network</i> to outstanding research.	
MEXT Scholarship	2022 - Present
Awarded by <i>Ministry of Education, Culture, Sports, Science and Technology, Japan</i> to outstanding master's and doctoral students.	
UCSI University Trust Scholarship	2017 - 2020
Merit-based scholarship granted by <i>UCSI University</i> to high-achieving undergraduate students.	

SKILLS

Software: Python, PyTorch, Linux, BigQuery SQL, Matlab, R, VBA Excel, Google Cloud Platform (GCP)
Languages: English (Bilingual, TOEIC 985), Mandarin (Native), Japanese (Fluent, JLPT N2), Malay (Fluent), Spanish (Basic)